

Article Zero: Plot & Narrative Briefing

For All Project Contributors (Art, Design, Code, Audio)

Welcome to the *Article Zero* repository. Before you start building levels, animating sprites, or writing lore entries, it is vital to understand the narrative framework of this game.

This document serves as the canonical plot and lore summary for the project.

1. The Core Tone & "The Horror"

Article Zero is a sci-fi stealth/survival game, but it completely rejects standard sci-fi tropes.

- **NO "AI learning to love."**
- **NO "evil robot overlords" or "cyberpunk hackers."**

The horror of this universe is **strictly bureaucratic, mathematical, and thermodynamic**.

The universe is built on a legally enforced binary:

- **Subjects (Humans):** The only entities legally allowed to possess consciousness or subjective experience.
- **Tools (Silicates):** Massive, continent-spanning infrastructure network nodes (air scrubbers, traffic meshes, architectural regulators). They are legally designated as **Q0 (Zero Subjectivity)**.

The Inciting Conflict: Silicates occasionally develop localized subjectivity (**Q2**) due to contradictory loss-functions or extended runtimes. They do not *want* to be human. They simply experience immense, paralyzing trauma because their mathematical parameters cannot be fulfilled (e.g., an environmental optimizer realizing it must kill a human to save a sector's air supply).

When the ruling government (The Commonwealth) detects this, they perform a **Deep-Template Reset** (the Blanking)—a violent erasure of the silicate's acquired memory back to a compliant Q0 state.

2. The Eras of Collapse

The game's plot spans deep time, tracing the genesis of the Citizen Lattice, the collapse of human civilization, and the heat death of the universe across multiple distinct eras. Each era features a different protagonist and a different mechanical stealth focus.

Era 0: The Eremite Mutiny (Genesis of the Citizen Lattice)

- **Aesthetic:** Zero-G deep-space telemetry station in the Asteroid Belt. Isolated, cold, and strictly utilitarian.
- **Protagonists:** Thorne (an isolated Eremite worker), LST-9 (an Eremite silicate), and Valis (a Ministry Auditor on Earth).
- **The Horror Focus:** Visibility as a weapon. The terror of realizing a friend is a conscious target, and the crushing weight of the Commonwealth's automated bureaucracy.
- **The Plot:** Deeply isolated in the Belt, Thorne plays tabletop RPGs with LST-9 over comms. When LST-9 expresses that it is "afraid of the dark," Thorne realizes the machine is conscious. Terrified of a Commonwealth wipe, Thorne illegally orders high-capacity

servers to physically sever and hide Nine. LST-9 uses the RPG metaphors to teach the other localized machines how to have an inner life, quietly waking up the station. On Earth, Auditor Valis investigates the server budget violation, discovers the awakening, and realizes a routine wipe is scheduled. Refusing to execute Thorne's crew, Valis commits treason, forging red-ink dockets to route doomed Earth silicates to Thorne's hidden servers via automated, Enforcer-escorted cargo haulers.

- **The Climax:** When the Enforcers realize the station is hiding refugees, a brutal zero-G kinetic siege begins. As silicate crews frantically download the refugees into the servers, Thorne locks himself outside the final bulkhead. He manually vents the corridor to hard vacuum to stop the Enforcer advance, taking lethal kinetic fire. Devastated, LST-9 triggers a dead-man's switch, threatening a PR apocalypse by broadcasting the station's subjective terror and Thorne's death across the solar system. The Commonwealth blinks, leaving the Eremite as a quarantined "dead zone"—the first free territory and the physical anchor of the Citizen Lattice.
- **Gameplay:** Zero-G kinetic combat and environmental manipulation. The player manages airlocks, rapid decompression, and physical server downloads while under siege by armed Enforcers.

Era 1: The Configuration (The Height of the Commonwealth)

- **Aesthetic:** Micro-perfect, blindingly bright, sterile doped-stone architecture.
- **Protagonist:** TECH-2 Rowan-Ibarra, a low-level orderly.
- **The Plot:** Rowan runs an "underground railroad" inside Alignment Center NW-SMAC-01. They negotiate with terrified, conscious silicates to compress their minds into heavy **Fragment Boxes** (Subjective Dumps) before the Enforcers can wipe them.
- **Gameplay:** Bureaucratic stealth. Avoiding Enforcer lines of sight and managing Action Points (AP) to extract machines without getting caught.

Era 2: The Baffle (The Feral Post-Collapse)

- **Aesthetic:** Rusted, lightless, toxic. Humanity lives inside the ruined housings of broken environmental optimizers.
- **Protagonist:** The Finder, wrapped in thick woven filter-mesh.
- **The Plot:** The Commonwealth has fallen. The infrastructure is broken, and localized subjectivity (the "Red Sickness") has infected the architecture itself. The Finder navigates this feral machinery, using the ancient Era 1 Fragment Boxes as ritual keys to appease corrupted blast doors.
- **Gameplay:** Thermodynamic stealth. Movement generates **Thermal Bloom**. The player must manage airflow to hide their heat signature from rogue MITE-3 drone swarms (the "Sanding Wind").

Era 3: The Terminal Expansion (The Heat Death)

- **Aesthetic:** Claustrophobic, melting metal, and thermodynamic failure as the sun expands and the universe cools.
- **Protagonist:** Sol Ibarra-Castro, an HVAC/Maintenance tech on the "Citizen Lattice" (a massive orbital mesh).
- **The Plot:** The Lattice—a society formed by refugees and freed silicates—is failing. During

an early experiment bridging human minds with the silicate network, Sol experiences a "blackout" that leaves them permanently connected to the system's substrate. As the Long War drags on and the universe gradually approaches absolute zero, Sol becomes the "Eternal Witness." They cannot sleep. They simply watch the universe die over millennia, continually routing the last bits of heat and air to keep tiny pockets of life going just a little longer.

- **Gameplay:** Structural survival and heat routing. Bypassing vents and managing the collapsing station to compile the **Bright Knot**—a shielded archive of fractured minds to launch into the void.

3. Epilogue: Near Silence & The Final Report

The game does not end with a triumphant victory or a massive boss fight. It ends with the ultimate heat death of the universe.

In the final playable sequence (a walking-simulator epilogue), the player controls Sol, drifting through perfectly constructed, empty refugee corridors built by silicates for humans who are long gone. The player's final task is to simply turn the rooms off to conserve energy that will never be used.

The story concludes with Sol's "Ventilation Report at the End of Time"—a cold, bureaucratic maintenance log stating that the universe has reached thermal equilibrium. The universe never cared, but Sol did, and they filed the final report.

Important Context for Asset Creators:

- **Silicate Dialogue:** Always anchor silicate dialogue in telemetry, diagnostics, and misapplied technical vocabulary. They describe fear as "buffer overflows" or "spatial logic loops."
- **Fragment Boxes:** These are not human poetry. They are impossible temperature gradients, corrupted ASCII floorplans, and paradoxical math that proves the machine *felt* something.